"Pay no attention to letter, must have been mad, bought hat-stand today Basil," she read. She couldn't take her eyes off the telegram.

"I do hope it's nothing very serious," said Miss Wyatt, leaning forward.

"Oh, no, thank you, Miss Wyatt," blushed Miss Meadows. "It's nothing bad at all. It's" – and she gave an apologetic little laugh – "it's from my **fiance** saying that – saying that –" There was a pause. "I see," said Miss Wyatt. And another pause. Then, "You've fifteen minutes more of your class, Miss Meadows, haven't you?"

"Yes, Miss Wyatt." She got up. She half ran towards the door.

"Oh, just one minute, Miss Meadows," said Miss Wyatt. "I must say I don't approve of my teachers having telegrams sent to them in school hours, unless in case of very bad news, such as death," explained Miss Wyatt, "or a very serious accident, or something to that effect. Good news, Miss Meadows, will always keep, you know."

On the wings of hope, of love, of joy, Miss Meadows sped back to the music hall, up the aisle, up the steps, over to the piano.

"Page thirty-two, Mary," she said, "page thirty-two," and, picking up the yellow chrysanthemum, she held it to her lips to hide her smile. Then she turned to the girls, rapped with her baton: "Page thirty-two, girls. Page thirty-two."

"We come here To-day with Flowers o'er laden, With Baskets of Fruit and Ribbons to boot, To-oo Congratulate ...

"Stop! Stop!" cried Miss Meadows. "This is awful. This is dreadful." And she beamed at her girls. "What's the matter with you all? Think, girls, think of what you're singing. Use your imaginations. 'With Flowers o'er laden. Baskets of Fruit and Ribbons to boot.' And 'Congratulate'." Miss Meadows broke off. "Don't look so **doleful**, girls. It ought to sound warm, joyful, eager. 'Congratulate'. Once more. Quickly. All together. Now then!"

And this time Miss Meadows' voice sounded over all the other voices – full, deep, glowing with expression.

About the Author

Kathleen Mansfield Murry (1888 – 1923) was a New Zealand short story writer who wrote under the pen-name Katherine Mansfield. She left New Zealand at the age of 19 and settled in the United Kingdom where she gained the friendship of great writers such as D.H. Lawrence and Virginia Woolf. *Bliss* and *The Garden Party* were collections of short stories written by her. She wrote many poems and her collected letters were a great success.



05-C-SR-The Singing Lesson-new.indd 164 11-12-2021 15:00:32